Aquifer Open Study Notes (Profiles)

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B

Babylon

Babylon, one of the world's oldest cities, was the center of Babylonian civilization. It is often used as a symbol for defiant human pride.

Nimrod founded Babylon a few generations after the flood (Genesis 10:8–10). He was one of the first powerful rulers in history. The name Babylon comes from Babel, which means "gate of god" in the Babylonian language. Babylon was likely where the tower of Babel stood (Genesis 11:1–9). This tower was an early human attempt to create an identity separate from the Creator. Abraham and his family left this proud civilization when they traveled from Ur of the Chaldeans around 2000 BC. Although many kingdoms ruled Babylon over the centuries, the city remained a cultural and religious leader.

Sumerian Civilization (3200–2000 BC)
The first major civilization in Babylonia was Sumer, located south of Babylon. The Sumerians created cuneiform writing, used by Mesopotamian cultures for three thousand years.

The Akkadian Empire (2334–2154 BC)
North of Babylon, King Sargon I of Akkad, who ruled from 2339 to 2279 BC, established the capital city of Akkad. He achieved political and cultural dominance over Mesopotamia. The Akkadian Empire lasted almost two centuries.

First Babylonian Kingdom (1900–1600 BC)
During the Akkadian Empire, Semitic-speaking nomads from Syria, known as Amurru or Amorites, migrated into Babylonia. The urbane Babylonians considered them barbarians. Eventually, they established a new Babylonian kingdom under Amorite control. Hammurabi, the sixth king of that dynasty, ruled from 1792 to 1750 BC and expanded the kingdom significantly. However, Babylon's glory was short-lived. Under Hammurabi's son, the kingdom declined and lasted only another century.

Assyrian Domination (900–614 BC)
In 851 BC, Assyrian King Shalmaneser III, who ruled from 858 to 824 BC, entered Babylon. He treated the ancient city with respect and allowed its king to remain as a vassal. About 150 years later, around 705 BC, a Babylonian vassal king named Merodach-baladan led a rebellion. He sent ambassadors to King Hezekiah of Judah for support (see 2 Kings 20:12–19; Isaiah 39). Assyria quickly crushed Merodach-baladan's rebellion, and its domination continued for another century.

Neo-Babylonian Empire (612–539 BC)
The Chaldean prince Nabopolassar took the throne of Babylon from 625 to 605 BC, ending the Assyrian Empire. His son, Nebuchadnezzar II, ruled from 605 to 562 BC. Under Nebuchadnezzar, Babylon became the leading power in the Near East and a city of great splendor (see Daniel 1–4).

After Nebuchadnezzar died, Nabonidus became the next king of Babylon. Nabonidus was once a high-ranking government official who worked with other kingdoms. He ruled Babylon from about 555 BC to 539 BC. Nabonidus neglected Babylon and lost its support. When Cyrus II of Persia, who ruled from 559 to 530 BC, attacked the city in October 539 BC (see Daniel 5:30–31 and study note on Daniel 5:31), the city surrendered without a battle. This surrender marked the end of independent Babylon.

The Symbolic Enemy of God's People
In 1 Peter and Revelation, Rome is represented by Babylon. Rome is "BABYLON THE GREAT, THE MOTHER OF PROSTITUTES AND OF THE ABOMINATIONS OF THE EARTH" (Revelation 17:5). It is portrayed as a very immoral center of wealth and trade, ruling over the earth's kings and persecuting God's people. The earth's kings and merchants will mourn its fall (Revelation 18:9–19). But God's people will celebrate because their oppression has ended and they can worship God freely.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 10:8–9; 11:1–9; 2 Kings 20:12–19; 24:1–25:30; Isaiah 39; Daniel 1–5; 1 Peter 5:13; Revelation 14:8; 16:19; 17:5; 18:2–21; 19:2

Balaam

Balaam was a diviner who read signs to predict the future and performed rituals to change it (see study note on Numbers 22:5–6; compare Joshua 13:22). He worked for money, so when Balak, the king of Moab, wanted to hire him to curse Israel, he was eager to start. Even when God told him not to go, he hoped God would change His mind because he was very interested in the money (2 Peter 2:15).

Finally, God allowed Balaam to go, but only if Balaam agreed to say what God instructed, aiming to frustrate Balak's plans (Deuteronomy 23:4–5). On the road, Balaam's donkey stopped and refused to move because the angel of the Lord blocked the way. The donkey could see the angel, but Balaam could not. Despite this, Balaam wisely chose not to curse the Israelites when God told him to bless them. To Balak's

great frustration, blessing them was all Balaam could do.

Recently, an inscription was found mentioning Balaam son of Beor, a diviner who had visions at night (see Numbers 22:9–12, 20). The inscription was written on a plaster wall at Deir 'Alla, eight miles east of the Jordan River, near where the Hebrews camped during the Balaam incident. This nonbiblical text, dated 800–750 BC, identifies Balaam as a "seer of the gods." It reports that the gods, whose names in the inscription resemble Shaddai ("Almighty"; see Numbers 24:4, 16), gave Balaam a message and announced judgment upon the world (see Numbers 24:15–25). The inscription provides rare evidence from outside the Bible about a character in the Bible.

Balaam's character and motives seem mixed in Numbers 22–24. Numbers 25 describes how the men of Israel sinned by being with Moabite women and worshiping their gods, which angered God. Although Balaam is not mentioned here, Numbers 31:16 identifies him as the one who started this plot. After his visions ended, Balaam stayed in Moab and looked for ways to harm Israel and earn money. The Israelites killed him shortly after (Numbers 31:8). Balaam became known as:

- A magician with bad intentions (see Deuteronomy 23:4–5; Joshua 13:22)
- A false teacher interested only in money (see Nehemiah 13:2; 2 Peter 2:15; Jude 1:11)
- Someone who led Israel into idolatry and immorality (Numbers 31:16; see Revelation 2:14)

Passages for Further Study

Numbers 22:1–25:18; 31:8, 16; Joshua 13:22; 2 Peter 2:15–16; Jude 1:11; Revelation 2:14

Barnabas

Barnabas is shown in Acts as a good example of a Christian leader. He was from Cyprus and was active in the Jerusalem church. Barnabas showed great generosity by helping poorer members (Acts 4:32–37). His real name was Joseph, but he was nicknamed Barnabas. Barnabas means "Son of Encouragement" and shows his character (Acts 4:36).

Barnabas was well-suited to fairly assess the new work in Antioch (Acts 11:19–22). Barnabas saw God's blessing there and encouraged believers to remain faithful to the Lord (Acts 11:23). His good character was evident in his kindness, strong faith, and Spirit-filled life and work (Acts 11:24). The Holy Spirit chose Barnabas and Saul for a special mission (known as the first missionary journey). The church at Antioch sent them out on this journey (Acts 13:1–3).

Barnabas showed wisdom when he went to Tarsus to find Saul (Acts 11:25). Barnabas admired Saul's bold preaching as a new Christian in Damascus. He introduced Saul to the apostles, which was important because Saul had previously attacked believers. Thanks to Barnabas, Saul met the original apostles, gained their acceptance, and preached bravely in Jerusalem until he had to leave (Acts 9:26–30). Barnabas's trip was successful, and for a year, they worked together in the Antioch church, attracting large crowds (Acts 11:26).

Barnabas was an important person. In Lystra, people even thought he was Zeus (see Acts 14:8–18). He was John Mark's cousin and mentor. Barnabas helped John Mark get a second chance to succeed as a Christian leader after he left an earlier mission (see Acts 15:36–40).

Barnabas understood how others could influence people to do wrong things. One time, he gave in to this pressure and did something he knew was wrong (Galatians 2:11–13). Barnabas was not perfect, but he was a "Son of Encouragement" to many. He was generous and unselfish, helping others and the church grow.

Passages for Further Study

Acts 4:36–37; 9:26–28; 11:19–30; 13:1–15:40; Galatians 2:1–14

Baruch

Baruch, the son of Neriah, was a royal scribe in Jerusalem. He worked as a secretary for the prophet Jeremiah. His brother, Seraiah, was a staff officer in Zedekiah's administration (Jeremiah 51:59–64). Baruch's family likely held a high position in Judah's administration.

In the fourth year of King Jehoiakim of Judah (605 BC), God told Jeremiah to write down the messages he had given to Israel, Judah, and other nations (Jeremiah 36:1–3). Jeremiah asked Baruch to write the prophecies (Jeremiah 36:4) and read them to the people (36:8–19). When Jehoiakim heard the message, he destroyed the scroll and ordered the arrest of Baruch and Jeremiah (Jeremiah 36:21–26). However, they hid, and Jeremiah repeated the prophecies while Baruch wrote them down again (Jeremiah 36:27–32).

Around that time, God sent Baruch a personal message through Jeremiah (Jeremiah 45). Baruch might have worried about losing career opportunities or personal comfort because of his connection with

Jeremiah. God reassured Baruch with a promise of protection and advised him not to seek "great things" for himself, as Judah's destruction was certain.

When Jerusalem was destroyed in 586 BC, Baruch stayed with Jeremiah and others who remained. Baruch seemed influential because the rebel leaders wanted to go to Egypt. When Jeremiah warned them not to go (Jeremiah 42), they accused Baruch of influencing Jeremiah. The leaders ignored the warning and took Baruch and Jeremiah to Egypt (Jeremiah 43:1–7). We do not know how, when, or where Baruch died. One tradition says he was taken to Babylon when Nebuchadnezzar invaded Egypt. It is also possible that Baruch died in Egypt.

God warned Baruch not to seek greatness, and he appeared to die without honor. However, his legacy may be the book of Jeremiah. He likely helped create this book, which warns of judgment and clearly expresses hope for the new covenant (Jeremiah 31:31–34).

In 1975, a clay impression (called a bulla) from a scribe's seal was found. It had the words "[Belonging to] Berechiahu, son of Neriahu, the scribe." (Berechiahu is the long form of the name Baruch.) Each scribe and government official had a unique seal with his name. They used it to seal documents, like a signature today. The seal was pressed into soft clay to make an impression (bulla), which was attached to the signed document. Baruch's bulla is from the time of Jeremiah and Baruch. Other bullae found include names of people in Jeremiah, like:

1. "Gemariah son of Shaphan" (Jeremiah 36:10–12, 25)
2. Ishmael (Jeremiah 40:7–41:10)

Most scholars agree that Baruch's bulla was made by Baruch's seal, Jeremiah's scribe. These bullae, small artifacts from an ancient civilization, provide independent historical proof of some details in Jeremiah's account.

Passages for Further Study

Jeremiah 32:9–15; 36:1–21, 26–32; 43:1–7; 45:1–5

Bathsheba

Bathsheba, the wife of Uriah, was Eliam's daughter (2 Samuel 11:3; see also 1 Chronicles 3:5). She was Ahithophel's granddaughter, the king's adviser (2 Samuel 15:12; 23:34). Her husband, Uriah, was a Hittite soldier. He was in King David's army and was one of David's mighty warriors (2 Samuel 23:39).

One spring, David stayed home in Jerusalem while the army went to battle (2 Samuel 11:1). Resting at midday, David walked on his roof overlooking the city and saw the beautiful Bathsheba bathing. He arranged for her to be brought to his private chambers. He then had sexual relations with her, and she became pregnant (2 Samuel 11:2–4).

David did not want people to find out what he had done wrong, so he tried to hide it. He told Joab, the general, to have Uriah bring back a report from the battle lines. David hoped Uriah would return home and have sexual relations with Bathsheba. This would make it look like she had become pregnant by Uriah. However, Uriah felt he was still on duty, so he slept at the palace gate instead (2 Samuel 11:5–13).

When David asked him about this, Uriah said he could not sleep with his wife while the ark of the covenant and Israel's armies were at war. This response made David look bad. Uriah was not even an Israelite, but he was ready to return to battle by avoiding being with his wife (see Leviticus 15:16–18). But David stayed home and tried to hide his adultery. Then David sent Uriah back and ordered Joab to ensure Uriah died in battle (2 Samuel 11:14–25). Uriah's death did not keep David's sin secret. The Lord sent the prophet Nathan to confront David, and David confessed his sin and repented (2 Samuel 12:1–14; see Psalm 51).

Bathsheba's baby became sick and died, as Nathan had predicted. After Bathsheba's mourning period, David brought her to the palace as his wife. David and Bathsheba had other children, including:

- Shimea
- Shobab
- Nathan
- Solomon (2 Samuel 12:15–25; 1 Chronicles 3:5)

For the rest of David's life, his wives and children fought against each other for power. The worst of this family fighting happened when David was old. At that time, Bathsheba worked to make sure her son Solomon would become the next king (1 Kings 1:1–53).

When Matthew lists Jesus the Messiah's family history, he mentions both Solomon and Bathsheba (Matthew 1:6). She is described as "Uriah's wife." This reminds us of the sin that brought her into David's family and of God's gracious favor toward her descendants.

Passages for Further Study

2 Samuel 11:1–12:25; 1 Kings 1:5–2:25; Psalm 51:1–19